Porus refers to the Puru tribe that had inhabited the area since the Rig Vedic times.

Alexander wanted to push on eastwards but his troops were tired after years on the march. Also, there were stories about a large Magadhan army that would be mobilized against them in the Gangetic plains. With his army in virtual mutiny, Alexander was forced to turn back. However, he did not go back the way he had come but fatefully chose to sail down the Indus under the mistaken belief that the Indus constituted the upper reaches of the Nile. The Macedonians thought that if they just sailed down the Indus, they would end up in the Mediterranean! They had reached this conclusion because of the apparent similarities between the flora and fauna of India and those of the upper reaches of the Nile (Arrian mentions crocodiles and a certain variety of beans). As Alexander's army sailed down the Indus, it defeated many tribes and brutally destroyed several settlements. There is also a fascinating account of how a local chieftain entertained Alexander with a gladiatorial match between a lion and ferocious dogs (the Indians claimed that the dogs had been bred from tigresses). [15]

On reaching the sea, the Macedonians discovered their mistake. They were then forced to march along the dry Makran and Persian Gulf coast. This was the same route that early humans had used when they migrated east to the subcontinent. However, climatic conditions and the coastline had dramatically changed. Without proper maps, provisions and water, the desert exacted a terrible toll. Soldiers and pack animals died in large numbers from hunger and thirst. Much of the plunder accumulated over years of campaigning had to be abandoned for lack of horses and men. Alexander's army arrived back in Babylon undefeated but decimated. The conqueror himself died soon afterwards, possibly poisoned by followers who no longer believed in his leadership. Alexander's empire was divided up amongst his generals and his young son was murdered. The lack of geographical knowledge proved deadlier than the sword. As we shall see, when Europeans attempted to take control of India two millennia later, they would take great care to map it.